

The book I chose for my report was “The Ghosts of Hero Street,” written by Carlos Harrison, on May 6, 2014. The reason why I chose this book was because of how much the title interested me, while “The Ghost of Hero Street” is the simpler version, the extended is “The Ghosts of Hero Street: How One Small Mexican-American Community Gave So Much in World War II and Korea”. I consider myself highly connected with my heritage. So the idea of a book about a community of people that are also from the same heritage & World War II, which is also my favorite history topic, all in one particular book, caught my interest. I expected to learn from this book how my people, even if it was a small group, left a long-lasting impact because they chose to help out in a war that didn’t directly involve them, but still gave their all, and in some for, helped out in the war.

The book begins with a banda gathering as it marches along a street in Silvis, Illinois. The mood is described as uplifting by the descriptions of the people cheering on the band, stating that the reason for such a mood is because of the war ending, as well as a memorial being added to the street for eight men, the street's renewed name best describes them: “*Hero*”. Fifty-eight Mexican families, among them in this street, fifty-seven servicemen emerged from the war, eight sacrificing their lives in the process. The book heavily weighs on the conditions that these families had to endure pre-war, segregation being a prominent feature in the book, as well as other conditions. As the war came during the 1940s, multiple sons of this street were enlisted into the army; Frank & Willie Sandoval being two of these numerous men. The book maintains focus on these two, as well as a few other men like Tony P. “Pancho” Ruiz, Joe Gomez, Joseph Sandoval, who served their time in the Korean War. The book does a wonderful job of expressing how these men's sacrifices don’t go in vain: “It would soar through the sky, but stand solidly on the ground of Hero Street— an imposing structure of marble and bronze, with artistic

touches hinting at both their Mexican roots and their American pride.” (pg 371). A little after the war & pre-Korean War, most of these men returned home to face the same prejudice they had been treated with before, although putting in their effort into a cause that didn’t involve them directly, showing how much these men wanted to reveal their American honor, but were still seemingly treated the same. Until the end, when those who sacrificed their lives finally received the honor they deserved, finally, when the committee saves up enough money to recognize them, to forever remember them, their legacy, and their honor. “This monument represents the ideal of duty, honor, and country as exemplified by the military service rendered to our nation by all American veterans during all wars to preserve freedom for the United States of America. A special tribute is mentioned here to honor the eight men from Hero Street USA who gave the supreme sacrifice during World War II and the Korean War. **We remember them**.” (pg 371-372).

The historical significance that the book held was how immigrants have always had to fight to earn respect as Americans. In this book, it shows how these men enlisted in the military to be respected & treated like whites, to earn their right in the community, in the states, but instead, after their multiple sacrifices, they still ended up being treated the same way. It took the committee fourteen years to finally have the ability to have these men be noticed & honored, to have their names marked into history. These men fought hard for what we take for granted now. Mexicans have strong patriotism for the states because it granted the ability for a better life for themselves and their families. It also shows how veterans fought for our country, enduring endless battles, their blood being spilled, comrades dying just for us to earn our freedom, fighting hard for the rest of us to earn an easier life. Mexicans and a large number of immigrants contributed to the United States, even if it wasn’t in the military services. Most people say

America was built on immigrants, and I have come to believe this is true. These men's sacrifices helped out the local & soon the national discussion of equality. The family's grief became something more, as families became activists for the fight for equality for Mexican Americans, to the point where the street was renamed "Hero Street USA". This is one of the early Latino representations for recognition and rights.

What I learned from this that correlates to US history is how much veterans sacrificed for us, going through unimaginable events like battles where you can lose your life at any point or see a friend pass in front of your very eyes, to be honored or not, depending on what race you are or how much people remember you, the possibility of never being remembered until years on or never at all, depending on those who choose to talk about your story. It's a horrifying thought, and to think so many men had experienced just that, to give it all for your country in honor of something as simple as respect or rights to be treated like others, that being even a slim possibility in its own. All you do for a country that might not even dare to treat you with the respect you deserve, or the privilege that you sought so much, just because you're different than the others whom they favor. The bare minimum that's so rarely given to veterans after war. Soldiers faced terrible, horrific events during WWII, witnessing things no human should ever see, and the villainous intent behind it all & how it affects everyone.

My personal reaction to this book was knowing that all these men fought for us, knowing what the outcome could be, to get the rights that we have nowadays have earned through them, & now treat them like a need instead of a privilege like they so wanted to. The book had me wondering what could've happened if the families didn't fight so hard for the community to recognize their children, their sons, who fought the hardest to keep their country safe. For them to finally have their name honored, respected, noticed, & admired, something they couldn't

receive alive but finally earned after their time in the world was completed. The book was tragic with knowing what happened to these men, it makes you think about how these are true stories that have actually happened to someone, to people like us. A sad read, but one that made me grateful for how things are today, and knowing how much immigrants fought for their places here on American soil.

I would definitely recommend this book to another person or a friend. I think I'd feel wrong if I didn't. This book should be heard more about. The author took his time with it, taking time to sit with the families affected and get every point of view in the book, honoring these men. Putting love into this book, one that should be more recognized within the Latino community, regardless of whether they're Mexican or not, it's an inspiring book with true passion put into it, making it readable and leaving a lasting impression.